river, the west-flowing Hari Rud. Although being a source for water, the river was not easily navigated or forded, and thus did not facilitate travel and communication. Nevertheless, its banks hosted at least two significant locales between modern Chaghcharan and Chisht-i Sharif, associated with the Shansabanis and their ancestors: Ahangaran lay on the river's southern bank, while the settlement of Jam-Firuzkuh straddled both banks (Figure 2.2). Each site was mentioned in Ghaznavid and later textual sources, respectively. While Ahangaran (see below) served as the seat of power of one or more of the local chieftains thought to be the forebears of the Shansabani sultans, the latter is now generally accepted to have been the summer capital – more likely a *sard-sir* royal encampment, as discussed further below and in Chapter 3 – of the initial branch of the Shansabanis of Firuzkuh (*c.* 1145 CE). These settlements and their respective roles for the Shansabanis and their predecessors are treated in succession.

The early fort and settlement of Ahangaran (Figures 2.1 and 2.3) was the site of the encounter between the Ghaznavid sultan Mahmud and the Ghuri chief Muhammad ibn Suri (d. 1011), referenced in Chapter 1. This chief evidently held some sway over the sub-region of Mandesh, which extended from the Hari Rud's southern banks northward to the borders of Darmashan, identified as another sub-region of Ghur. Thus, even though Ahangaran appeared to be the northernmost fortress of Ghur in pre-modern times, the conceptual frontiers of the region lay farther northeast and northwest, encompassing, respectively, the Chaghcharan basin through the edges of Gharjistan.[22] Southward, Mandesh stretched to the very heartland of Ghur, which was anchored by the mountain peak of Chehel Abdal. Kohzad (1954a: 23) noted in the mid-twentieth century that the area around Chehel Abdal and the Mandesh region overall "ha[d] all the necessities for animal rearing and husbandry," implying that subsistence in the region was quite possible.[23]

Modern documentation at the historical site of Ahangaran (Figures 2.1 and 2.3), a fortification with two concentric walls atop a rocky promontory rising gently above the Hari Rud, shows cultivated fields below stretching to the river banks and relying on it for irrigation.[24] Notwithstanding changes in the region's geo-climatic features over the centuries, it is conceivable that historically also, Ahangaran and its vicinity were home to largely transhumant populations. These groups resided in constructed villages – such as Ahangaran itself – only in the colder winter months, and moved into tents on the banks of the Hari Rud during the warmer periods of the year.[25] In modern times, specifically the mid-twentieth century, the well-watered Ahangaran Valley's inhabitants were not only agriculturalists, some among them also wove rugs. The valley in fact witnessed the constant visits of nomadic populations, many traveling to the month-long Khirgai market near Chagcharan, which was "a yearly meeting of nomads from [Afghanistan's] remotest corners." There, brisk trade occurred in